

Perception Gap Report

Document Structure — Goodspell

The deliverable of every Perception Audit engagement. A single document, 4–6 pages, written. Complete. No open questions. Written after the questionnaire, the session, and the independent research — not before, not in parallel.

Section 1 — What Your Presence Currently Signals

Purpose: What the market reads when it sees you — not what you intend to communicate.

1.1 — First Impression Audit

What someone who looks you up for the first time finds — online, LinkedIn, website, any public touchpoint. Described from the perspective of an external observer. Not a list of problems — a coherent narrative about what impression forms and why.

The question it answers: If I didn't know you at all and searched for you now — what would be there about you and why would I care or not?

1.2 — Involuntary Signals

What your presence communicates unintentionally:

- Absences — what is missing and what the absence suggests
- Inconsistencies — where the presence contradicts reality
- Associations — what category, level, or type of business you involuntarily align yourself with

"The website positions you as a generalist operator in a market where specialists command three times your current rate. Nothing on the page contradicts this reading — which means nothing on the page earns the trust your actual track record would justify."

Section 2 — What Your Business Actually Is

Purpose: Distilled reality — not the client's self-presentation, but what you understood from everything you heard and saw.

2.1 — What You Have Actually Built

Not a description of services — a description of substance. What exists in reality that does not appear publicly. Written from your perspective. The client does not need to recognize themselves immediately — they need to feel that someone saw what they could not articulate.

2.2 — Why You Are Difficult to Replace

Specific. Not "vast experience" or "personalized approach." Exactly what makes the business hard to copy and hard to replace — derived from the discovery, not from what the client wrote in the form.

2.3 — Who You Actually Are for the Right Clients

What role you actually play in the lives of the clients who work best. Not the service category — the real function.

"What you've built is not a consulting practice. It is a diagnostic function that your clients don't have internally and can't hire for permanently. The engagements that work best are the ones where the client already knows something is wrong but can't locate it. That's the real product — location, not solution."

Section 3 — Where the Gap Lives

Purpose: Precise localization of the divergence between Section 1 and Section 2. This is the most important section of the report.

3.1 — The Primary Gap

A single paragraph. The most important place where public presence and business reality diverge. Not a list — a single central observation, written with maximum precision. If there is one thing the client takes away from the entire report, this is it.

3.2 — Secondary Gaps

2–3 specific observations about other points of divergence. Each with: the exact place where it appears, what it signals relative to what exists in reality, and why it matters. Complete sentences. No more than one paragraph per secondary gap.

3.3 — What Amplifies the Gap

Factors in the market or in the client's behavior that make the gap more visible or more costly. Not judgment — observation.

"The primary gap is not visual. It is categorical. Your presence places you in the execution market — designers, consultants, implementers — while your actual work operates at the decision layer, before execution begins."

Section 4 — What the Gap Costs

Purpose: Concrete consequences — not abstract, not potential, but what is already happening.

- Cost in pricing conversations — How the gap affects bargaining power and the type of pricing conversation the client has now versus what they would have with a presence aligned to reality.
- Cost in client quality — What type of client arrives now versus what type should be arriving. Not in demographic terms — in terms of fit, understanding, and ease of relationship.
- Cost in market authority — How the gap affects perception by peers, partners, potential employees, or investors. Not just by clients.
- Cost in energy — Repeated explanations. Conversations that should not be necessary. Time spent justifying what should be obvious. The most invisible cost and the most real one.

"The pricing conversation takes longer than it should because the presence doesn't do the work before the meeting. You arrive at the table having already spent authority you haven't been given. Every engagement starts with a deficit."

Section 5 — What Needs to Happen Next

Purpose: Direction — without execution recommendations, without roadmap, without pitch.

5.1 — What Needs to Be Solved First

A single priority. Not a list of actions — a clear direction about where any intervention must begin and why.

Written so the client understands the logic, not just the conclusion.

5.2 — What Should Not Be Touched Until the First Thing Is Resolved

As important as 5.1. If the client does something in the wrong order, they waste resources and deepen the gap.

Tell them directly.

5.3 — The Question They Need to Ask Themselves

Not a recommendation. A precise question the client needs to take forward — alone or with help. The question that, if answered clearly, unlocks everything else.

"Before anything is redesigned or rewritten, one question needs a written answer: what is this business for someone who has never heard of it and has thirty seconds to decide if it's worth their attention?"

Writing Reminders

- Section 3 is the most important. If you cannot locate the gap precisely — not generically — the report is not complete.
- Section 5 sells nothing. If you feel yourself slipping toward an execution recommendation or a pitch for the next engagement — stop. The client senses the difference immediately.
- The tone is consistent throughout. It does not soften in Section 4 and does not become diplomatic in Section 5. The client paid for precision, not for comfort.